CLEO · AI GUIDES

Smart Home AI Guide

How to build a genuinely useful AI-powered home — step by step, without wasted money or constant technical headaches.

Alexa · Google Home · HomeKit · Home Assistant · Philips Hue · Nest · Ring · Eufy · Automations

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INTRODUCTION

Build a Home That Works for You, Not Against You

Most smart home advice falls into one of two traps: it either assumes you want to spend weekends configuring YAML files, or it's basically an ad for Amazon Echo. This guide is neither.

Every exercise includes exact steps — which app to open, which menu to navigate to, what to tap. You shouldn't need to guess or Google anything. Open your phone alongside this guide and follow along.

The honest starting point: a smart home built badly is worse than no smart home. Unreliable automations and fragmented apps are not improvements to your life. We'll build it properly.

The principles this guide follows

- Start small. One room, one automation. Expand when you know what you want.
- Pick one ecosystem and stick to it. Mixing platforms creates problems.
- Reliability beats features. A light that always works beats one that's impressive but flaky.
- Privacy matters. Know what your devices are sending and to whom.

6	25+	5	£360
Areas covered in depth	Step-by-step exercises	Automations to build first	Starter setup budget

01 FOUNDATION

Choosing Your Platform

The most important decision you'll make — get this right and everything else follows

Before buying a single device, choose your platform. This is the ecosystem that all your devices will live in. Mixing platforms creates complexity and unreliability. Pick one and commit to it.

The four options

- → **Amazon Alexa** — widest device compatibility, easiest to get started. Best if you're already an Amazon household or want the most device choice.
- → **Google Home** — best voice intelligence, tight Calendar/Gmail integration. Best for Android users and anyone who asks factual questions frequently.
- → **Apple HomeKit** — strongest privacy (local processing), iPhone-native. Best if you're an iPhone household and privacy matters to you.
- → **Home Assistant** — runs locally on a Raspberry Pi, no cloud, works offline, unlimited compatibility. Best for technical enthusiasts willing to invest a weekend in setup.

Google Home at home.google.com — sign in with your Google account to manage devices, create automations, and see your home layout.

⚡ Try This — Choose Your Platform in 3 Questions

1 What phone do you use?

1. iPhone household: HomeKit is the natural fit. Open your iPhone's **Home app** (already installed) — this is your HomeKit control centre. No separate hub needed to start.
2. Android/Google household: Go to **home.google.com** and sign in with your Google account. This is Google Home — your control centre is already waiting.
3. Mixed or no preference: Google Home gives the best balance of capability and compatibility for most people. Use home.google.com to explore before committing.

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2 How much do you care about privacy?

1. If you care about what data your devices send and to whom, HomeKit is the only mainstream option designed around local processing. Open Apple's **Home app** and read the privacy summary at the bottom of any device's settings page — it shows what each device accesses.
2. If you want full local control with no cloud at all, visit **home-assistant.io** and read the Getting Started guide. Be honest with yourself: are you comfortable spending 3–4 hours on initial setup? If yes, it's worth it long-term.
3. If privacy is not your primary concern, any of the three mainstream platforms work well. Choose based on your phone ecosystem instead.

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3 Lock in your choice and explore it for 30 minutes before buying anything

1. Open the app for your chosen platform: **Amazon Alexa app**, **Google Home app**, **Apple Home app**, or the Home Assistant web interface.
2. Browse the "Add a device" or "Devices" section. Note which brands are compatible with your platform.
3. Search "[your chosen platform] compatible devices" and read for 10 minutes. Understand the ecosystem before spending money.
4. Only now proceed to buying hardware. Any device you buy should be confirmed compatible with your chosen platform before purchase.

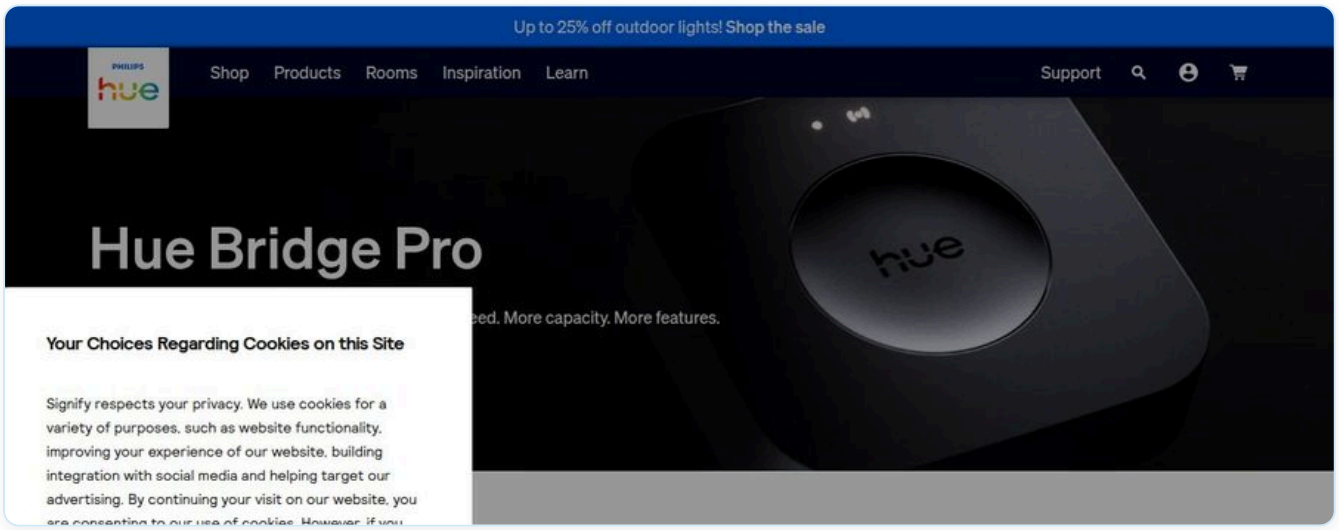
Bottom line: iPhone + privacy priority → HomeKit. Android/Google → Google Home. Amazon household → Alexa. Technical enthusiast → Home Assistant. Whatever you choose: don't mix ecosystems. Pick one and stick with it for at least 12 months.

02 LIGHTING

Smart Lighting

The highest ROI smart home upgrade — you interact with lights dozens of times a day

From £5/bulb · Bridge £60 philips-hue.com · ikea.com



The Philips Hue website — download the Hue app from your app store after connecting the Bridge to your router. The Automations tab is where all the exercises below live.

Smart lighting gives you more practical benefit per pound than any other smart home category. Even small improvements compound quickly when you interact with something dozens of times a day.

Which bulbs to buy

→ **Philips Hue** (£15–25/bulb + £60 Bridge hub) — most reliable, best app, works with every platform. The Bridge hub communicates directly with bulbs rather than via WiFi — faster, more reliable.

→ **IKEA Tradfri** (£5–12/bulb) — significantly cheaper, uses same Zigbee protocol as Hue, genuinely reliable for basic use. Works with Alexa, Google, and HomeKit.

⚡ Try This — Step-by-Step Exercises

1 Set up Adaptive Lighting — the single automation everyone should have

1. Download the **Philips Hue app** from your app store. Plug in your Bridge hub, connect it to your router with the included ethernet cable, and follow the in-app setup. Takes about 5 minutes.
2. Add your bulbs by tapping **Add device** in the app. The app will walk you through pairing each bulb.
3. Tap on a room in your home. Tap the three-dot menu in the top right. Select **Adaptive Lighting**.
4. Toggle Adaptive Lighting **On**. Set your wake time and sleep time. The bulb now automatically shifts from cool white in the morning (energising) to warm amber in the evening (sleep-friendly).
5. Live with it for one week before judging. Most people stop thinking about it consciously but notice they feel better in the evenings.

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2 Set up a leaving home automation — never leave lights on again

1. In the Hue app, tap the **Automations** tab at the bottom of the screen.
2. Tap **+** to create a new automation. Select **When someone leaves home** as the trigger.
3. When prompted, allow the app to use your phone's location. This is what detects when you've left.
4. Set the action to **Turn off all lights**. Select all rooms.
5. Tap **Save**. The next time you leave, every light turns off automatically. Test it: leave your home and watch the lights go off on the app's live view.

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3 Set up a sunrise alarm — wake up better than any sound alarm

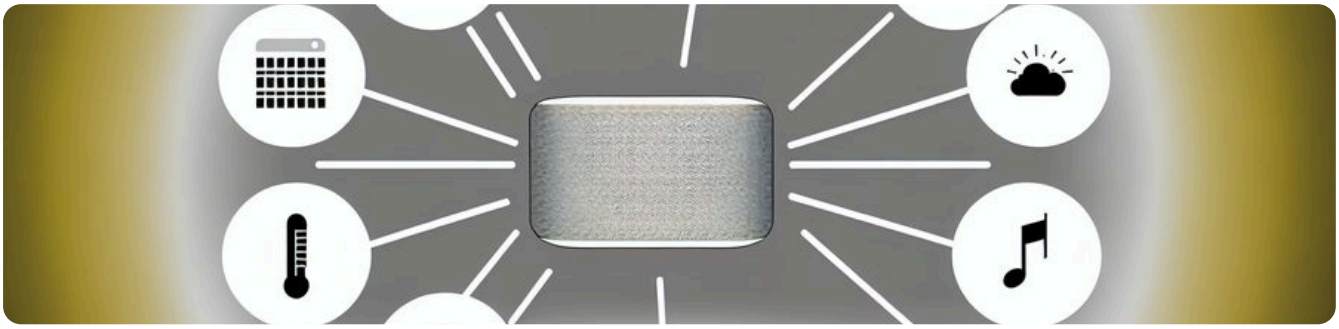
1. In the Hue app, go to **Automations → + → Wake up**.
2. Set the time to 20–30 minutes before your usual wake time. Select your bedroom bulb(s) only.
3. Set the start brightness to **1%** (barely visible) and end brightness to **80%**. Start colour: warm orange. End colour: bright white.
4. Enable it on the days you use an alarm. Tap **Save**.
5. The light will gradually brighten, mimicking sunrise. Your body begins waking naturally before the sound alarm fires. Give it a week — most people find they're waking up just before the alarm, feeling more rested.

Bottom line: Philips Hue if budget allows — the reliability is worth the cost. IKEA Tradfri if you want to save money. Start with one room. Get adaptive lighting working first before adding more automations.

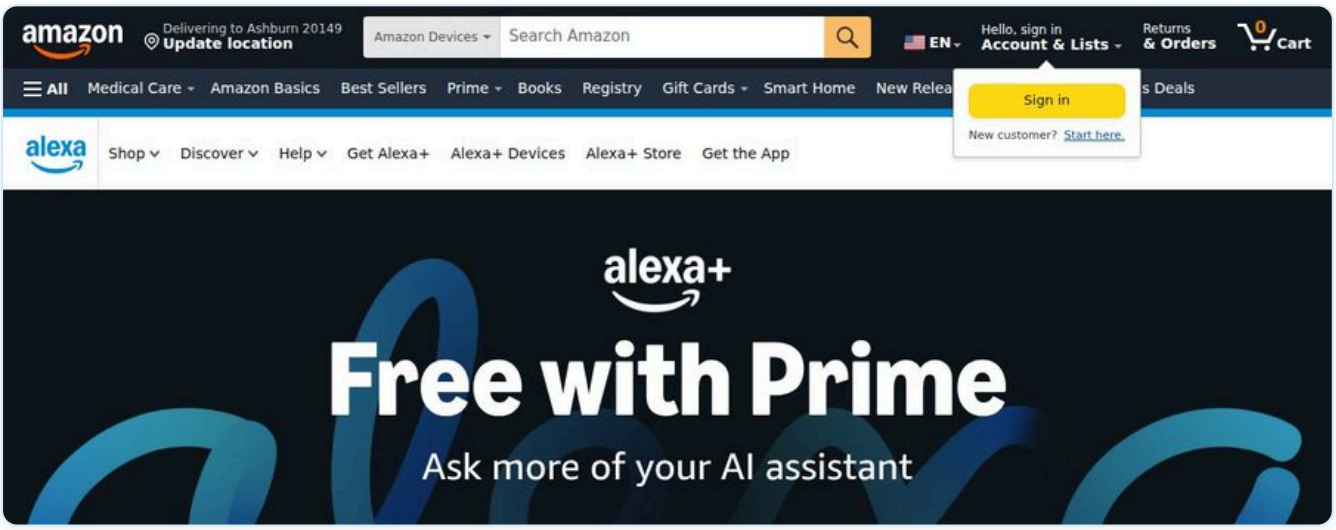
03 VOICE CONTROL

Voice Assistants

Most people use 10% of what voice assistants can do — here's the rest



Echo Dot from £25 · Google Nest Mini £30 · HomePod Mini £99



The Amazon Alexa app — Routines are in the bottom nav. This is where you build voice-triggered automations that control your whole home with a single phrase.

The power of a voice assistant is not answering questions — it's acting as the control layer for your entire home. One phrase triggering a whole-home scene is where this becomes genuinely life-changing.

⚡ Try This — Step-by-Step Exercises

1 Build a "Good night" scene — one phrase replacing ten actions

1. **In Alexa:**
   Open the Alexa app → tap
   More
   (bottom right) → tap
   Routines
   → tap
   +
   .
2. Tap
   When this happens
   →
   Voice
   → type *"Good night"* as the trigger phrase.
3. Tap
   Add action
   →
   Smart Home
   →
   Control group
   → select all lights → set to
   Off
   .
4. Add another action:
   Smart Home
   → your thermostat → set to your sleep temperature.
5. Tap
   Save
   . Say "Alexa, good night." Every light turns off, the thermostat adjusts. One phrase. Test it tonight.

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2 Set up a location-based reminder (more useful than a time-based one)

1. Open the
   Google Home app
   or
   Alexa app
   on your phone.
2. Say to your assistant: *"Remind me when I arrive at [your nearest supermarket] to buy [item]."*
3. Your phone's GPS triggers the reminder at exactly the moment you can act on it — not at 3pm when you're in a meeting and forget by the time you leave.
4. Use this for any recurring errand triggered by location. After a week, compare how often you remember things compared to time-based reminders.

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3 Set up a shared shopping list

1. In the **Alexa app**: tap **Lists** in the bottom nav. Your Shopping List is already there. Share it with a household member by tapping the share icon and inviting their email.
2. **In Google Home**: Google Shopping list syncs via Google Keep. Open **keep.google.com**, create a list called "Shopping", and share it with household members.
3. For one week, add everything verbally as soon as you notice you need it: "Alexa, add milk to my shopping list" — while standing at the fridge, while cooking, any time. Don't write anything down.
4. Review the list before you shop. Compare completeness to your previous lists. This habit is genuinely difficult to give up once established.

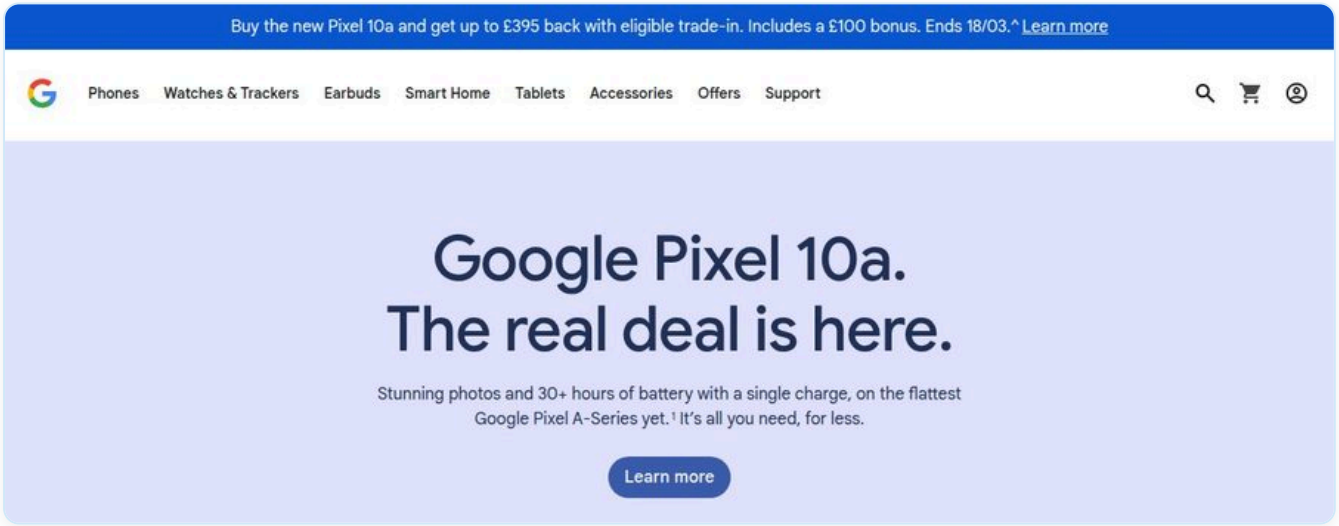
Bottom line: One assistant, one ecosystem. Don't buy a separate brand's speaker if you've chosen a platform — use the native one. The power is in scenes and automations, not answering questions.

04 CLIMATE

Smart Thermostats

The smart home purchase with the clearest financial return — 10–15% heating cost reduction

Google Nest £219 · Ecobee $189 store.google.com/nest · ecobee.com



The Google Nest thermostat product page — after installation, download the Google Home app to access Home/Away Assist and Energy History. Both are in the thermostat's settings section.

A smart thermostat pays for itself. Data from millions of homes shows 10–15% reduction in heating and cooling costs. The payback period on a £219 Nest is typically 1–2 years in energy savings. The key feature is Home/Away Assist — enable it on day one.

⚡ Try This — Step-by-Step Setup After Installing

1 Enable Home/Away Assist immediately — this is the most important step

1. Download the **Google Home app** on your phone (if not already installed). Sign in with your Google account.
2. Tap your Nest thermostat in the Home app. Tap the **Settings cog** in the top right.
3. Scroll down to **Home/Away Assist**. Tap it.
4. Enable **Use phone location**. This allows your phone's GPS to tell the thermostat when you've left. Allow location access when prompted.
5. Set your **Away temperature** (the temperature the house holds when empty). For most people, 15°C (heating) or 26°C (cooling) is appropriate. Save. The thermostat now stops heating or cooling an empty house automatically.

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2 Let the Nest learn your schedule — adjust manually for one week

1. For the first 7 days after installation, adjust the Nest manually whenever you're uncomfortable — directly on the thermostat dial or in the Google Home app.
2. The Nest records every manual adjustment and uses them to build your schedule. This is more accurate than entering a schedule yourself because it captures your real behaviour, not your estimated behaviour.
3. After 7 days, tap your thermostat in the Google Home app → **Settings → Schedule**. Review the schedule it's built. It should be largely correct. Make minor adjustments if needed.
4. Leave it running for a further week. After day 14, the schedule is usually settled enough to trust without monitoring.

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3 Calculate your actual savings after 3 months

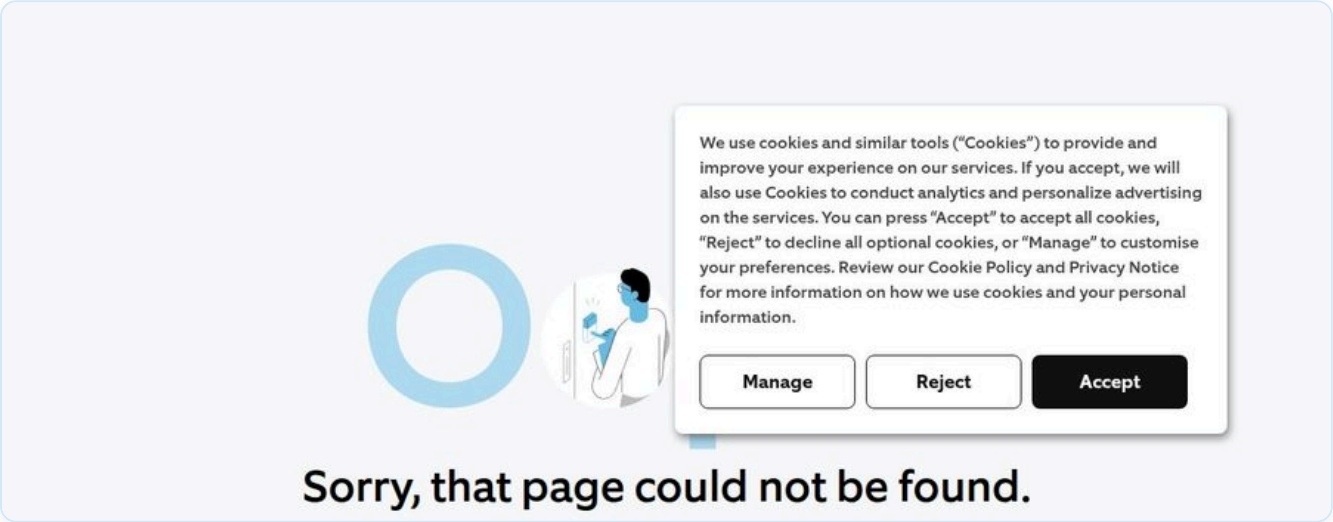
1. In the Google Home app, tap your thermostat → **Energy History**. This shows your heating/cooling runtime by day and week.
2. Find your gas or electricity bill for this 3-month period. Note the usage in kWh or the cost.
3. Find the equivalent 3-month period from last year on old bills. Compare.
4. Note the temperature difference between the two periods (colder winters use more energy regardless of the thermostat). Adjust your comparison accordingly.
5. Calculate: at what month does the energy saving equal the thermostat's purchase price? Most households: month 18–24. That's a 50–100% annual return after payback — better than most investments.

Bottom line: The smart home purchase with the clearest financial return. Google Nest for most households. Ecobee for larger homes where different rooms have different occupancy patterns. Enable Home/Away Assist the same day you install it — that single feature accounts for most of the savings.

05 SECURITY

Security & Cameras

AI-powered doorbells and cameras — setup, zone configuration, and what to lock down



Ring's website at ring.com — after hardware installation, the Ring app (iOS/Android) handles all zone configuration, AI detection settings, and privacy controls covered in the exercises below.

Which doorbell to buy

- → **Ring Video Doorbell** — better hardware at lower price, wide third-party integration. Subscription ($3.99/month) required to store video history beyond 60 seconds.
- → **Google Nest Doorbell** — on-device AI, no subscription needed for basic features, better at distinguishing people/packages/animals in notifications.

For indoor cameras: Eufy is the privacy-respecting option — local storage, no cloud, no subscription, footage never leaves your home. Think carefully before installing indoor cameras; know who has access to the footage.

⚡ Try This — Step-by-Step Setup Exercises

1 Configure AI motion zones — stop your phone buzzing every time a car passes

1. Open the **Ring app** on your phone. Tap your doorbell device from the home screen.
2. Tap **Device Settings → Motion Settings → Motion Zones**.
3. You'll see a live camera view with a blue zone overlay. The default zone is too large — it covers the road and pavement. Drag the zone handles inward so it only covers your path and immediate front area.
4. Under **Smart Alerts**, change from **All Motion** to **People Only**. This uses Ring's AI to filter out cars, animals, and blowing branches.
5. Tap Save. Live with the new settings for 3 days. Adjust the zone further if you're still getting unwanted alerts or missing ones you want.

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2 Enable package detection — get notified when deliveries arrive

1. In the Ring app, tap your doorbell → **Device Settings → Smart Alerts**.
2. Find **Package Detection** and toggle it **On**.
3. Your phone will now receive a specific "Package detected" notification (distinct from a general motion alert) when a parcel is left at your door.
4. For the Nest Doorbell: open **Google Home app** → tap your doorbell → **Settings → Familiar Faces & Notifications → Package alerts → On**.
5. If you order online regularly, this is the notification you'll actually value. You'll know exactly when deliveries arrive without checking cameras throughout the day.

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3 Audit your privacy settings — do this for every smart device you own

1. Open the **Ring app → Control Center** (accessible from the main menu). Find **Neighbours & Public Safety**. Read what's enabled. If you're not comfortable sharing footage with law enforcement or neighbours automatically, adjust these settings to your preference.
2. In **Ring app → Account → Privacy Settings**: review data sharing options. Disable any categories you're not actively using.
3. For **every** smart home device you own, check: are firmware updates automatic? If not, update manually and enable auto-updates. Security patches matter on internet-connected devices.
4. Check your router's connected devices list. Do you recognise every device on it? If not, investigate before adding more smart devices.

Bottom line: Nest Doorbell if you're in the Google ecosystem. Ring for Alexa or if you want to save on hardware. For indoor cameras, Eufy is the privacy-respecting choice. Always configure motion zones before relying on alerts — the defaults are useless.

06 AUTOMATIONS

Automations That Work

The 5 automations worth building first — with exact steps for Alexa and Google Home

The rules for automations that actually get used

- **Only automate things you already do.** Automations that do something you wouldn't have done anyway create noise, not value.
- **Always have a manual override.** Every automation needs to be easily bypassed. If it can't be, you'll resent it.
- **Test for a week before trusting it.** Run it alongside your manual behaviour. Only stop doing it manually when the automation has proved consistent.

⚡ Build These 5 Automations — In Order

1 Morning routine (Alexa)

1. Open
   Alexa app → More → Routines → +
   .
2. Trigger:
   Schedule
   → set to your weekday alarm time.
3. Add action:
   Smart Home → lights → bedroom
   → set to 20% warm white. Add a second action:
   Smart Home → thermostat
   → set to your morning temperature.
4. Save and enable. Tomorrow morning your bedroom is already at the right temperature and gently lit before you've opened your eyes.

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2 Leaving home — lights off, thermostat away (Google Home)

1. Open
   Google Home app → Automations → + (Create) → Personal automation
   .
2. Starter:
   When I leave home
   . Allow location access.
3. Actions:
   Adjust lights → Turn off → All rooms
   . Add action:
   Adjust thermostat → Away
   .
4. Save. The next time you leave, the house goes into away mode automatically. "Did I leave the lights on?" becomes a question you never ask again.

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3 Arriving home — lights on, thermostat home (Google Home)

1. Same path:
   Google Home → Automations → + → Personal automation
   .
2. Starter:
   When I arrive home
   .
3. Actions:
   Adjust lights → hallway → On (warm, 70%)
   . Add action:
   Adjust thermostat → Home
   .
4. Save. The house is comfortable and lit before you've taken your coat off. Combine this with Nest's Home/Away Assist for fastest thermostat response.

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4 Evening wind-down — lights warm and dim (Philips Hue)

1. In the
   Hue app → Automations → + → Timer
   .
2. Set time: your preferred evening wind-down time (e.g. 9:30pm). Select all rooms.
3. Action: set brightness to
   30%
   and colour temperature to
   warmest setting
   (2200K or "candlelight").
4. Save. Every night at 9:30, the house softens. Environmental cue for winding down — more effective than any app reminder, because it's ambient not interruptive.

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5 "Good night" scene — voice command, everything off

1. **In Alexa:**
   Routines → + → Trigger: Voice → "Good night" → Actions: all lights off, thermostat to sleep temp. Save.
2. **In Google Home:**
   Automations → + → Voice command → "Good night" → Turn off all lights, set thermostat. Save.
3. Test it tonight. Say "Good night" to your assistant. One phrase, whole house responds. This is the automation most people use every single day and never want to give up.

> **Bottom line:** Build these 5 first, in this order. Live with each for a week before adding more. A home with 5 automations that always work beats one with 50 that sometimes fail.

YOUR STARTER SETUP

The Best £350–400 Smart Home From Scratch

If you're starting from nothing, here's what to buy and in what order.
Each step builds on the last — don't skip ahead.

1

£30–50

Smart Speaker first

Google Nest Mini or Amazon Echo Dot. Get comfortable with voice control before adding any other devices. Set up your chosen ecosystem app. Spend a week just using voice commands for lights, timers, and weather. This step teaches you how voice control actually works before you invest heavily.

2

~£80

Smart Lighting — one room

3× Philips Hue White bulbs + Bridge for your living room or kitchen. Set up Adaptive Lighting immediately (Hue app → room → Adaptive Lighting → On). Add a motion sensor (£20) in the hallway. Build automations 4 and 5 from the list above. Now you have a living home.

3

£219

Google Nest Thermostat

Highest financial return of any smart home purchase. Enable Home/Away Assist the same day. Let it learn your schedule for 7 days before making any manual adjustments. Check Energy History at 30 days — you'll already see the savings.

4

~£15

One Smart Plug

For one device you want on/off control of — a coffee maker, a lamp, a fan. Create one automation with it (on at 7am, off at 11pm). Experience what basic automation feels like at low cost before expanding.

5

Wait 3 months

Live with it before expanding

Your wish list at month 3 will be far more accurate than any guide's suggestion for what comes next — because it'll be based on what you actually notice missing, not what sounds appealing in theory.

PRIVACY & SECURITY

Stay in Control of Your Own Home

Smart home devices expand your digital attack surface. These aren't optional considerations — they're the difference between a smart home that works for you and one that works against you.

Change default passwords

Every router, hub, and device ships with a default password. Change all of them. Use a password manager. A compromised smart plug can be a gateway to your entire network.

Put devices on a guest network

Your router has a guest WiFi option. Put all smart home devices on it, separate from your computers and phones. If a device is compromised, it can't access your main network.

Enable automatic firmware updates

Smart devices receive security patches. Enable auto-update in each device's settings. For devices without it, check manually every 3 months. Unpatched IoT devices are a known security risk.

Know what you've agreed to

Ring shares footage with law enforcement by default — adjust this in Control Center if it concerns you. Review privacy settings on every device. Disable data sharing you haven't consciously opted into.

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